OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Mayor White and CEO Constance Face Public Questions on Roads, Rates and the MRF

Sent 25 June 2026 · To Council Email · Response requested by 9 July 2026

Eye on Shoalhaven Council
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25 June 2026

OPEN LETTER — for publication
NOTE TO COUNCILLORS - The questions BELOW have been put to the Mayor and the CEO on the public record. On past experience, they will not be answered. Correspondence from this publication has been formally declined, and that refusal is itself the subject of a complaint currently before the NSW Ombudsman. Elected councillors, however, are in a position this publication is not: you can compel these matters onto the floor of the chamber. A Question on Notice, a question to the Mayor in open council, or a Notice of Motion requiring a written report on roads spending, the rate variation outcome, or the MRF capital cost — any of these would place the questions in a forum where a response cannot simply be declined. Shoalhaven residents voted for roads, rates and rubbish. They deserve to know, on the public record, what has been delivered against each of those promises and when the gap will be closed. If the Mayor and the CEO will not answer a publisher, they should answer the chamber.

Mayor Patricia White
Shoalhaven City Council
Bridge Road, Nowra NSW 2541
mayor@shoalhaven.nsw.gov.au
CC: The Hon. Andrew Constance, Chief Executive Officer — andrew.constance@shoalhaven.nsw.gov.au

Re: SIG Election Promises — Roads, Rates and Rubbish — and Three Questions for the Public Record

Dear Mayor White,

I write in the knowledge that correspondence from this publication has, in recent months, been declined on the basis of guidance relating to unreasonable conduct. I note, for the record, that the application of that guidance to a public interest publication with more than 3,800 local readers is itself a matter currently before the NSW Ombudsman. The questions in this letter are not personal complaints. They are questions of public administration, put openly, on behalf of a readership that represents approximately 5.1

per cent of Shoalhaven's registered voters. They are questions any member of the public could put at an ordinary council meeting. I put them here, in writing, on the public record — and will publish whatever response is received, including none.

The mandate

The Shoalhaven Independent Group won the September 2024 election on three specific promises. They appeared on authorised flyers, in media releases, and in public statements by you and your fellow candidates. They were not aspirations. They were a contract with voters:

"FIX Shoalhaven's ROADS & POTHOLES — Fix it once, fix it right." "STOP Council's out of control future RATE INCREASES." A separate SIG media release committed to a "special Road Maintenance and Repair Fund," a dedicated Chief Roads Engineer, a Roads Condition Strategy, and weekly transparency to residents on progress.

Those commitments were the basis on which voters extended their trust to the SIG council majority in December 2024.

What the record shows

Eighteen months into that mandate, the documented position is as follows:

Roads: The road renewal backlog stands at $280 million. Council's own Infrastructure Renewals Ratio for the General Fund is 90.1 per cent — meaning assets are degrading faster than they are being renewed. Roads spending as a proportion of the total budget has fallen from roughly 20 per cent to just over 6 per cent — a figure placed on the public record not by a critic but by SIG Councillor Peter Wilkins at the 26 May 2026 ordinary meeting.

Rates: A 12 per cent Special Rate Variation took effect from 1 July 2025, adding approximately $6 million annually and roughly $200 per household per year to rate bills. The SIG campaign attacked a 44 per cent "secret rise" attributed to the previous council. That figure was debunked modelling — the previous administration's actual proposed increase was 4.5 per cent. The SIG council delivered more than twice that.

The Materials Recovery Facility: The MRF is the centrepiece of the council's financial recovery narrative. At the 26 May 2026 ordinary meeting you acknowledged publicly that the MRF had experienced a cost blowout. The original approved budget for the facility and the final construction cost have not been disclosed to residents.

Three questions for you, Mayor White

I ask that you provide answers on the public record, for publication in Eye on Shoalhaven Council:

Question 1: What is roads spending as a percentage of total council expenditure in the adopted 2026–27 budget, and what is council's documented plan and timeline to close the $280 million road renewal backlog? Question 2: The SIG platform explicitly committed to

stopping “out of control” rate increases. The Special Rate Variation imposed a 12 per cent rise. What is your account of how that outcome is consistent with the mandate voters gave SIG in 2024? Question 3: What was the original approved capital budget for the Materials Recovery Facility, and what is the final cost? When will that comparison be reported transparently to residents?

Note to Mr Constance, copied as CEO

The above questions are addressed to Mayor White in her capacity as the elected leader of the SIG council majority and the person who campaigned on and is accountable for the promises made to voters. They are copied to you as CEO because some of the answers — budget allocations, the MRF capital cost, the infrastructure renewals ratio — are operational matters within your direct responsibility.

I therefore put one further question to you directly, Mr Constance:
Question 4: The SIG council majority was elected on a platform of roads, rates and rubbish. Roads spending has fallen to 6 per cent of the budget. The road renewal backlog is $280 million. The rate rise exceeded anything the previous council proposed. These are outcomes that occurred on your watch as CEO. What is your operational plan to bring council’s actual performance into alignment with the mandate its elected majority was given — and what is your timeline for doing so?

These questions are asked in good faith, on behalf of Shoalhaven residents who voted for specific outcomes and are entitled to a clear public account of progress toward them. They will be published, together with any response received, in Eye on Shoalhaven Council. Responses are welcomed within 14 days of the date of this letter.

Yours sincerely,
Steve Prothero
Publisher, Eye on Shoalhaven Council

25 June 2026